the 1950s. It will lose and win elections, but the systemic dominance of the BJP in India's polity is of that order.

When the political scientist W.H. Morris-Jones visited the Congress's party office in Bhopal in 1967 to research what held the party together, he was waved off by a committed party worker 'hard at work over a desk' who told him he was 'busy'. When Morris-Jones persisted, the worker responded, 'Look, you must understand. I am working for the party and nobody can interfere with this work.'[77] The political scientist finally got what he was looking for from other party officials, but he later recalled that this encounter 'opened' his eyes. There were, he wrote, 'several of his kind to be found in dusty Congress offices up and down the country, slaves dedicated to the cause'. These party workers were legatees of Gandhi's exhortation to the service ethic, which had harnessed the 'traditional call of *seva* to the modern party machine'. By 2020, it was possible to find such dedicated men and women—karyakartas—in brand-new BJP offices across India. I met and had conversations with many of them—from UP, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh in the Hindi heartland to Karnataka and Telangana in the South and Gujarat in the West—while researching this book. It was almost impossible to find a comparable cohort of dedicated ideological workers (as opposed to leaders) in the Congress offices.

What is the big differentiator between the old BJP and the new BJP? When I put this question to a district leader in Mathura, he told me: 'Earlier, as a party worker, we used to work only during election times. In the new BJP, we work daily. We are given daily tasks and we send in a daily report to the level above us. They don't let us sit for a moment. That is the difference. Earlier, we used to have our district-level party meetings only in the evenings, after we finished work and closed our shops. Now we have it daily at 11 a.m. and everyone turns up. Attendance is marked.' Many scholars of the BJP, not abreast of the shift at the ground level, continue to believe that the BJP is somehow winning elections only because of the power of money or by subverting institutions. The party does have money-power. For decades, so did the Congress. But to think that the BJP is growing only because of this is wishful thinking based on an older style of studying politics that is well past its use-by date.